

pace to win the second set 6-4, clinching it with a backhand crosscourt winner. Rybakina eventually overpowered the solid but less aggressive American and wound up with 36 winners, including 15 aces, to only nine winners for Pegula.

In the other semifinal, Sabalenka exacted still more revenge against Amanda Anisimova (**right**), who upset her 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 in the Wimbledon semifinals. Sabalenka avenged that 6-3, 7-6(3) in the U.S. Open final and again at Riyadh with a 6-3, 3-6, 6-3 victory.

Anisimova, one of the Tour's most improved players, had eight top 10 wins before 2025 and notched 10 this year, including victories over Swiatek and Keys in round-robin matches at the WTA Finals.

Fitter and faster than ever, the 24-year-old American also improved her first serve power and precision. Sabalenka and Anisimova slugged it out for 2 hours and 21 minutes like two heavyweight boxers in a title bout. "This is first-strike tennis at its best," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Chanda Rubin.

The battle-tested Anisimova boasted a confidence-inspiring 15-4 record this season in three-set matches, but Sabalenka drew first blood in the deciding set with a ferocious backhand service winner to break for 4-3.

Sabalenka staved off a break point in the next game to hold for 5-3 and then broke serve again to wrap up the victory. "What a battle!" said Davenport. "Aryna had to dig deep in the third set." And what a year for Anisimova! She started the year ranked No. 36 and finished it No. 4.

Anisimova is finally fulfilling the potential she showed as a 15-year-old when she won the 2017 US Open junior title. Less than two years later as a pro, Amanda upset No. 3 and defending champion Simona Halep before making the Roland Garros semifinals to become the first player (man or woman) born in the 2000s to advance to this stage of a Major.

The Rybakina-Sabalenka final featured another battle of 'Big Babe Tennis', an expression coined by the

esteemed broadcaster Mary Carillo. But this contest would prove as much mental as physical. "Aryna may be emotionally and physically fresher," said Rubin. "But she carries the huge burden of falling short in the first two Majors, and a lot of disappointment to get over early in the year, and the pressure of being No. 1."

Although Sabalenka has overcome the double-faulting woes that plagued her several years ago, she can still succumb to nerves. Serving at 2-3, she committed two unforced forehand errors and inexplicably hit a routine overhead into the net on break point.

But Rybakina's relentless power created a bigger problem. The Kazakh was hitting much harder, 11 mph faster on her picture-perfect backhand and 9 mph faster on her improved forehand.

While not known for her defence, Rybakina also scrambled and retrieved better than ever. Taking coach Vukov's advice, she retreated two feet behind the baseline to return Sabalenka's potent first serve, a tactic that worked.

After Rybakina took the opening set 6-3, with 16 winners to just five for Sabalenka, Davenport said, "Rybakina is playing fearlessly. Can she keep up this level?"

Rybakina did exactly that in the second set, holding serve easily in every game except the 10th when she escaped two break points. Faltering under pressure, Sabalenka committed two unforced forehand errors, and then on game point, missed an easy forehand off a smart, change-of-pace semi-moonball from Rybakina.

For her part, the Belarusian staved off two break points of her own in the third game and two more in the ninth game with clutch serving that produced three aces.

Based on her outstanding play, Rybakina looked like she had a slight edge going into the tiebreaker. But four-time Major champion Sabalenka evened the odds with a superb 22-2 tiebreaker record this year.

Rybakina delivered the knockout punch with a stunningly fast and

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efficient 7-0 tiebreak, huge serves and returns along with nervous errors by Sabalenka doing the trick.

While Sabalenka cracked under the pressure in the tiebreaker, the far bigger story was Rybakina's all-court superiority and poise. She belted 13 aces and saved all five break points in the convincing 6-3, 7-6(0) triumph. "The serve was the big weapon, and she used it well under pressure," noted Rubin. "That forehand was the difference maker. She volleyed well and had the touch at net."

Sabalenka put it best during the trophy ceremony when she said, "You literally smashed me off the court."

With her coaching chaos resolved by the return of Vukov, Rybakina should join Sabalenka, Swiatek, Gauff, and Anisimova as the leaders of a new Big Five next season. Unless talented teenagers Mirra Andreeva, already No. 9, and Victoria Mboko, along with veterans Naomi Osaka and Karolina Muchova, challenge the quintet.